

VentureMiner AI

Onboarding & Activation Playbook

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Document 37 — Onboarding & Activation Playbook

How we get a new user to their first useful artifact in 10 minutes or less — and how we keep them coming back. The contract for the activation funnel.

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1. Purpose & Scope

This document is the contract for onboarding and activation. It governs:

- The user journey from signup to "aha moment".
- The in-product onboarding flow.
- The activation metrics and counter-metrics.
- The re-engagement motions.
- The experimentation roadmap.

It does not cover sales (Document 32) or support (Document 33) — though both are downstream consumers of activation data.

2. Activation principles

1. Time to value is the only metric that matters. Ship the user to their first useful artifact in < 10 minutes.
2. Show, don't tell. Use their data, their seed, their outcome.
3. Reduce decisions. Defaults that work > choice paralysis.
4. Earn the next step. Each step earns the right to ask for the next.
5. No dead ends. Every state has a clear next action.

3.1 North Star

Validated opportunities acted on per week per active user.

- Captures the behavior we want: not just generating, but acting.
- Increases with breadth (more opportunities) and depth (more action).

3.2 Counter-metrics (to prevent gaming)

Reports-per-user (cap)	Prevent farming	≤ 30/week/paid user
Report rejection rate	Quality	≤ 5%
Subscription churn (per cohort)	Stickiness	< 3% monthly
Time-to-first-edit	Quality proxy	< 5 min p75

4. User journey (per persona)

4.1 Indie founder

Signup → Onboarding tour → Sample brief → "Try your own" CTA →
Run discovery (their seed) → Pin a hit → Validate (Quick) →
See score → Generate brief → Export → AHA

Time to AHA: 8 min (target).

4.2 Corporate innovator

Signup → Choose "Corporate" track → Onboarding tour (corp-specific) →
Upload competitor list → Run adjacency exploration →
Pin 3 candidates → Compare → Generate board report →
Share with team → AHA

Time to AHA: 10 min (target).

4.3 Investor

Signup → Choose "Investor" track → Onboarding tour →
Add a watchlist (sector, keywords) → Run discovery →
Pin a candidate → Generate deal memo → AHA

Time to AHA: 7 min (target).

4.4 Consultant

Signup → Choose "Consultant" track → Onboarding tour →
Create a client workspace (template) → Run a white-label report →
Preview → AHA

Time to AHA: 9 min (target).

5. Onboarding flow

5.1 Components

- Sample artifact (one-click) — generates a sample brief in their industry.
- Activation checklist (persistent) — 5 actions to reach AHA.
- Empty states — each empty state shows a "Try this" CTA.
- Tooltips — contextual, dismissable.

5.2 The 5-step activation checklist

1. Complete profile (workspace name, persona).
2. Run first discovery (1-click with their seed).
3. Pin one opportunity (1-click).
4. Run first validation (Quick depth, 1-click).
5. Generate first report (1-click).

Each step is logged; the checklist UI shows progress and the next step.

5.3 Sample data

- Sample seed library — 50 industry-specific seeds.
- Sample opportunities — 5 pre-generated, fully cited.
- Sample reports — 3 anonymized templates.

6. Activation checkpoints

C0 — Signup	Account created	Volume
C1 — Activated	First artifact generated	70% of signups in 7d
C2 — Engaged	3+ artifacts in 14d	50% of activated
C3 — Habit	1+ artifact per week for 4 weeks	40% of engaged
C4 — Power	10+ artifacts per week for 4 weeks	10% of habit

7. First 7 days

7.1 Email cadence

0	"Welcome — your first brief in 60s"	CTA to sample
1	"Did you try your own seed?"	CTA to first discovery
3	"3 things you can do in 3 minutes"	Activation checklist nudge
5	"How [Persona] use VentureMiner"	Case study
7	"Your weekly summary"	Recap + next steps

7.2 In-product nudges

- Day 0: sample artifact CTA.
- Day 1 (if no discovery): "Run your first discovery in 90s."
- Day 3 (if < 3 artifacts): checklist nudge.
- Day 7 (if habit forming): "Subscribe to weekly digest."

8. First 30 days

8.1 Habit loop

- Trigger: weekly digest email + in-app notification.
- Action: open app → view trends → validate top opportunity.
- Reward: new score / new evidence / new trend.

8.2 Activation events that prompt upgrade

- 3rd workspace attempted on Solo → upgrade CTA to Team.
- Custom rubric requested on Solo → upgrade CTA to Team.
- Audit log viewed on Team → upgrade CTA to Enterprise.
- SSO attempted on Team → upgrade CTA to Enterprise.

9. Re-engagement

9.1 Inactive users (no login in 14d)

- Day 14: "Here's what changed" email — top 3 new trends in their watched categories.
- Day 21: "Your pinned opportunities have new evidence" — value-reminder email.
- Day 30: "We saved your workspace — come back?" — one-click login.
- Day 60: Suppress; do not email.

9.2 Lapsed paid users

- Day 7 post-cancel: "What changed?" survey (1 question).
- Day 30 post-cancel: "Your data is here" — soft win-back.
- Day 60 post-cancel: Suppress; add to win-back list (90+ days).

10. Cohort analyses

10.1 Standard cohorts

- By persona — how does activation differ by self-reported persona?
- By acquisition channel — paid vs organic vs referral.

10.2 Standard dashboards

- Funnel: C0 → C1 → C2 → C3 → C4 (per cohort).
- Time to AHA (p50, p75, p90).
- Activation by step — where do users drop off the checklist?
- Re-engagement rate — % of inactive users who return.

11. Experimentation roadmap

11.1 Q4 2026 (alpha)

- Test: persona selector in welcome modal vs. no selector.
- Test: product tour skippable vs. forced.
- Test: 5-step checklist vs. 3-step.

11.2 Q1 2027 (beta)

- Test: sample brief as default vs. sample discovery.
- Test: email cadence density (3 vs. 5 emails in week 1).
- Test: AHA definition (first brief vs. first pin).

11.3 Q2 2027 (pre-launch)

- Test: paywall timing (immediate vs. after 5 reports).
- Test: pricing display (per-seat vs. per-workspace).
- Test: re-engagement subject lines.

12. Appendix

12.1 Glossary

AHA	The moment a user understands the product's value
Activation	The first session where the user reaches AHA
Habit	Repeat usage ≥ 1 session/week for 4 weeks
Cohort	Users grouped by a shared attribute (e.g. signup week)
Win-back	A re-engagement campaign targeted at lapsed users

12.2 Revision history

v0.5	2026-07-20	Doc Team	All sections drafted
v1.0	2026-07-20	Doc Team	First approved version

12.3 Cross-references

- PRD: Document 01 §6.2.
- Application Flow: Document 03 §3.
- UI/UX: Document 04 §12.
- Marketing Site: Document 34.
- Support: Document 33.

End of Document 37 — Onboarding & Activation Playbook. Time to value is the only metric that matters in the first week.